

knows how many thousands have lost their lives to COVID because they believed conspiracies about the vaccines. Especially in the west, the disinformation is at its highest.

On the other hand, a well regulated media who is scared of ever saying anything against the government and the laws the government makes, are also just as useless as the cacophony of no filters in the US.

In essence, much like what we do when it comes to voting, we have to choose the least of all the evils. And we have to decide which side of the fence we stand on. Or do we?

FENCE SITTING

Speech without consequences just does not work. We're 700-odd words in, so it's time for Godwin's Law to kick in. Hitler used his right to free speech to demonise Jewish people, and as a result, 6 million of them were killed in the holocaust. Using arguments of national pride, doing what's best for the fatherland, and many other logical fallacies to prop up his argument, Hitler was able to arm twist an entire country into doing something deplorable. If you opposed the obvious demonisation of Jewish people, you were a traitor to the fatherland, and abused filthily by self-proclaimed patriots. Standing up for human rights or secularism could get you killed, even if you were a member of the so-called superior race!

Fence sitters in times like that, are irrelevant. Thus, the need to choose a path forwards, even if it's a bumpy road, and that's exactly where we end up... discussing the future of Twitter.

Elon's take is simplistic (or certainly it seems so, because Twitter forces brevity of messaging). He started off by mocking those opposing him and his desire for free speech. When people started posting replies about how free speech also includes deplorable speech, he chose to write a clarification.

"By 'free speech', I simply mean that which matches the law. I am against censorship that goes far beyond the law. If people want less free speech, they will ask govern-

ment to pass laws to that effect. Therefore, going beyond the law is contrary to the will of the people.", Musk posted on Twitter.

But which laws, of which countries? If we go by the laws of the country the user registered their account, then essentially we have 193 different rules for 193 different countries! Hailing from South Africa, Elon has grown up in a country that had some of the most inhuman laws on the planet, literally treating dark-skinned South Africans as dirt! Will Twitter uphold unjust laws from dictatorships and squash free speech at the behest of corrupt governments? Taking away free speech from the very people who need it the most?

Or will twitter follow just American laws, which are pretty

pants or shirts, not global social media companies!

CROSSROADS

Honestly, I think we can safely assume that Musk, like all others before who have tried to handle social media behemoths, will have to pick and choose battles and make compromises to remain profitable. And let's be clear, it has to remain profitable. Musk may be a lot of things, but he's not foolish, and isn't going to wipe out billions of dollars of his personal wealth just to be stubborn. He's not going to run Twitter into the ground, of this you can be 100% sure.

This may all turn out to just be a storm in a teacup, as Twitter gets a new boss, but continues not too

differently from the way it is being run at the moment. Sure, there might be fewer permanent bans of famous voices, even radical ones, but the laws of various countries, especially in Europe and Asia, will still demand that disinformation be shut down. Being a private company instead of a publicly traded one might actually help there.

The other possibility is that Musk will deliver on his

promises, as he's done with Tesla and SpaceX. Given his rapid rise to becoming the richest man alive, he obviously knows how to be successful. He wants to open source the Twitter algorithm and code, keep speech free for all, and get rid of bots. All of those things inherently sound like brilliant ideas, if one can find a way around the complexities of laws and geography.

Whatever the final outcome, and whether it will be better or worse for society as a whole, it is not going to change the fact that we're all going to need to develop thicker skin on Twitter. **d**



flawed, but also more importantly, in direct contradiction to laws elsewhere. A simple example is laws about keeping the peace. In the US, the desire of the law to keep the peace is secondary to individual rights, whereas in most of the world, keeping the peace trumps personal rights to offend others. Will Twitter get banned in all countries but the US for not following local laws?

Honestly, it seems almost impulsive how he has approached this whole situation, and in what kind of world can someone make a 44 billion dollar impulse buy? People normally have those kinds of impulses with